KCE PATHWAYS · GRADES 4–5 · UNIT 3: BUILDING THINGS · WEEK 12 · READING

Building Up Houston: Informative Writing, Paragraphs and Transitions — Teacher Lesson Plan & Answer Key

Learning objectives: Students write and analyze informative paragraphs with a topic sentence, supporting details that stay on one idea, transition words chosen for the right job (first, next, however, for example, as a result, finally), and a concluding sentence. They sort sentences into the right paragraph, spot off-topic sentences, and write their own paragraph.

Duration: 35–45 minutes
Materials: Computer or tablet with the lesson open · pencil · printed Pre & Post sheet

Lesson flow (as it appears on screen)

1. Slide 0 · Intro and name capture: the student types first and last name so results go to KingCretot Experience. Preview the Houston apartment build and the quest list.
2. Slide 1 · Warm-Up Review (Week 11, punctuating dialogue): two quick items per set on commas and capitals with tags, end marks inside quotes, and new paragraphs for new speakers.
3. Slide 2 · Pencil Break (Pre): the student completes the Pre-Lesson Warm-Up sheet on paper before any teaching.
4. Slide 3 · Picture It: Build a Paragraph Like a Building. Walk through the paragraph tower (topic sentence on top, detail floors joined by transitions, concluding sentence at the base), the color-coded safety-gear model paragraph, the parts chart, and the “stay on one idea” warning with an off-topic example.
5. Slide 4 · Transition Words: Hallways Between Ideas. Go through the chart by JOB (order, example, contrast, effect, add), the comma rule after an opening transition, and the worked example (the crane broke down → As a result). Have the student say the job of each transition out loud.
6. Slide 5 · Vocabulary flip cards: informative writing, topic sentence, supporting detail, transition, concluding sentence, off-topic.
7. Slide 6 · Vocabulary practice: one multiple-choice item and one typed item per set (typed answers accept reasonable variants, such as “transitions” or “conclusion”).
8. Slide 7 · Article Part 1 (paragraphs 1–3) with a cutaway illustration of the building, the clay soil and the piers, plus one comprehension item. As the student reads, have them point to each topic sentence and each transition word.
9. Slide 8 · Article Part 2 (paragraphs 4–6) plus one comprehension item. Ask: what does the concluding paragraph look back on?
10. Slide 9 · Paragraph Builder: a paragraph map of the article (paragraphs 2–5), then one “sort the sentence into the right paragraph” item and one “spot the off-topic sentence” item per set. Have the student name the topic sentence before choosing.
11. Slide 10 · Transition Detective: one “choose the transition” item and one “which explanation is correct / find the mistake” item per set. Ask the student to name the JOB (order, example, contrast, effect) before picking.
12. Slide 11 · Fix the Sentence (4 typed items per set): a comma after an opening transition, capitalization of proper nouns, a grammar fix (subject-verb agreement or their/there), and an end mark or apostrophe. Checked exactly (curly or straight apostrophes and extra spaces are OK). The corrected sentence appears after the 2nd miss.

13. Slide 12 · Writer's Notebook (unscored, bonus XP): the student types a 4–6 sentence informative paragraph. The Check button confirms 4–6 sentences, at least two transition words, and a capital/end mark; the student self-checks topic sentence, staying on one idea, and the concluding sentence. Read the paragraph together. Then one scored follow-up item per set (choose the best topic or concluding sentence).
14. Slide 13 · Match-Up Round: 5 term/meaning pairs, 2 points per first-try match.
15. Slide 14 · Speed Trail (bonus XP only): 3 quick questions about transitions and topic sentences against the student's own best time.
16. Slide 15 · Boss Challenge: two two-step items per set (find and fix the off-topic sentence, choose the correctly organized paragraph, order sentences using the topic sentence and transitions, explain a transition misuse, or list ALL the mistakes).
17. Slide 16 · Pencil Break (Post): the student completes the Post-Lesson Challenge sheet, including the paragraph-writing item.
18. Slide 17 · Results: score out of 100, sent to KingCretot Experience. 85+ shows the Paragraph Builder congratulations with a big confetti burst; below 85 shows encouragement and a fresh question set on the next try.

Lesson answer key with reasoning

Every scored item the student sees, in order, across all three rotating question sets. The "why" is the same reasoning shown on screen after a second missed try.

WARM-UP REVIEW: PUNCTUATING DIALOGUE, WEEK 11 (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
rv1_s0	Which sentence is punctuated CORRECTLY?	**"The crane is ready," Marisol said.**	When the tag comes after the quote, the spoken words end with a comma INSIDE the closing quotation mark, and only Marisol's exact words go inside the quotation marks.
rv2_s0	In a story, Marisol finishes talking, and then Andre answers her. What should the writer do when Andre starts speaking?	**Start a new paragraph**	Every time a new character speaks, the writer starts a new paragraph (Week 11).
rv1_s1	Find the mistake! Andre asked, "where does the steel go?" What is wrong?	**The first word of the quote, "where," should be capitalized.**	The first word inside the quotation marks always gets a capital letter: Andre asked, "Where does the steel go?"
rv2_s1	Look at this line: "Is the concrete dry?" Andre asked. Which explanation for why there is NO comma after "dry" is correct?	**The question mark takes the place of the comma, and it stays inside the closing quotation mark.**	A question mark or exclamation point replaces the comma. You never use both, and the end mark stays inside the quotation marks (Week 11).
rv1_s2	The dialogue tag comes FIRST in these sentences. Which one is punctuated CORRECTLY?	**Andre said, "The crane is tall."**	Tag first: put a comma after the tag, capitalize the first word of the quote, and keep the period inside the closing quotation mark.
rv2_s2	Find the mistake! "We start at sunrise," She said. What is wrong?	**"She" should be lowercase, because the tag finishes the same sentence.**	When the tag comes after the quote, it continues the same sentence, so a pronoun like "she" stays lowercase: "We start at sunrise," she said.

VOCABULARY PRACTICE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
v1_s0	The sentence that tells the main idea of a paragraph is the ___.	**Topic sentence**	The topic sentence states the main idea, and it usually comes first in the paragraph.
v2_s0	Type your answer: words like first, next and however that connect one idea to the next are called ___ words.	**transition (also accept: transitions, transitional)**	Words that connect one idea to the next are transition words.
v1_s1	Facts, examples, and explanations that back up the main idea are called ___.	**Supporting details**	Supporting details are the facts, examples, and explanations that prove or explain the main idea.
v2_s1	Type your answer: the last sentence of a paragraph, the one that wraps up the main idea, is called the ___ sentence.	**concluding (also accept: conclusion, closing, ending, final)**	The sentence that wraps up a paragraph is the concluding sentence.
v1_s2	Writing that teaches the reader facts about a real topic is called ___ writing.	**Informative**	Informative writing teaches facts about a real topic. Narrative writing tells a story, and persuasive writing tries to convince the reader.
v2_s2	Type your answer: a sentence that wanders away from the main idea of a paragraph is called an ___ sentence.	**off-topic (also accept: off topic, offtopic, unrelated, irrelevant)**	A sentence that does not support the main idea is off-topic.

ARTICLE PART 1 (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
p1_s0	According to paragraph 2, why is clay soil a problem for buildings?	**It swells when it is wet and shrinks when it is dry, so it can push and pull on a building**	Paragraph 2 says the clay "soaks up water and swells" when it rains and "shrinks and cracks" when it is dry, and that "this movement can push and pull on a building."
p1_s1	Which sentence is the TOPIC SENTENCE of paragraph 3?	**"Next, the crew builds the frame, which is the skeleton of the building."**	The first sentence names the main idea of the whole paragraph: building the frame. Every other sentence gives a detail about the frame.
p1_s2	According to paragraph 3, why do builders use steel AND concrete together?	**Concrete is strong when squeezed and steel is strong when stretched, so together they make a stronger frame**	Paragraph 3 explains that concrete "can crack when it is stretched or bent," but steel "is strong when it is stretched," so "together, the two materials make a frame that is much stronger than either one alone."

ARTICLE PART 2 (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
p2_s0	What is the MAIN IDEA of paragraph 4?	**The building must be ready for hurricanes, including strong winds and flooding**	The topic sentence says the building "must also be ready for hurricanes," and every detail is about wind or flooding. The choice about Hurricane Harvey in 2017 is only one detail.

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
p2_s1	According to paragraph 4, what happened after Hurricane Harvey flooded Houston in 2017?	**The city passed stricter rules, so many new buildings in flood areas must have their lowest floor built higher**	Paragraph 4 says the city "passed stricter rules for building in areas that flood," and "as a result," many new buildings there must have "their lowest floor built higher off the ground."
p2_s2	How does paragraph 6 work as the CONCLUSION of the article?	**It sums up the main parts of the build and ends with a final thought for the reader**	Paragraph 6 looks back at the piers, the frame, and the storm-ready windows and floors, then leaves the reader with a final thought about the teamwork behind each new home.

PARAGRAPH BUILDER: SORT IT AND SPOT THE OFF-TOPIC SENTENCE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
pb1_s0	Sort it! Which paragraph of the article does this NEW sentence belong in? "Plumbers test every pipe for leaks before the walls are closed up."	**Paragraph 5: the crew**	This sentence describes a job one of the workers does, so it belongs with the other crew jobs in paragraph 5.
pb2_s0	Spot the off-topic sentence! Which sentence does NOT belong in this paragraph? / (1) Houston builders must plan for heavy rain. (2) Drains around the building carry water away quickly. (3) Some roofs slope so that rain runs off. (4) Houston is home to a famous space center.	**Sentence 4: "Houston is home to a famous space center."**	The topic sentence is about planning for heavy rain. Sentences 2 and 3 support it, but the space center has nothing to do with rain, so sentence 4 is off-topic.
pb1_s1	Sort it! Which paragraph of the article does this NEW sentence belong in? "Some windows are tested by hitting them with flying boards to prove they can survive a storm."	**Paragraph 4: getting ready for hurricanes and floods**	This sentence is about making the building strong enough for storms, so it belongs in paragraph 4 with the storm-ready windows.
pb2_s1	Spot the off-topic sentence! Which sentence does NOT belong in this paragraph? / (1) Clay soil changes with the weather. (2) After a rainy week, it swells. (3) The Houston Astros play baseball downtown. (4) During a dry summer, it shrinks and cracks.	**Sentence 3: "The Houston Astros play baseball downtown."**	The topic sentence is about clay soil changing with the weather. A baseball team has nothing to do with clay soil, so sentence 3 is off-topic.
pb1_s2	Sort it! Which paragraph of the article does this NEW sentence belong in? "The deeper the piers go, the less the swelling clay can push them around."	**Paragraph 2: the foundation and the clay soil**	This sentence is about the piers and the clay soil, so it belongs in paragraph 2, which explains the foundation.
pb2_s2	Spot the off-topic sentence! Which sentence does NOT belong in this paragraph? / (1) Many workers share the job of building. (2) Electricians run the wires. (3) Hurricane season begins in June. (4) Plumbers connect the pipes.	**Sentence 3: "Hurricane season begins in June."**	The topic sentence is about the workers who share the job. Hurricane season is not about workers, so sentence 3 is off-topic.

TRANSITION DETECTIVE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
td1_s0	Choose the best transition: The morning was cool and calm. ___, the afternoon brought a thunderstorm, and the crew had to stop work.	**However**	A calm morning and a stormy afternoon are opposites, so the writer needs a contrast transition: However.
td2_s0	In paragraph 2, the writer starts the last sentence with "As a result." Which explanation is correct?	**It shows an effect: the building has solid support because of the deep piers described just before it.**	"As a result" signals cause and effect. The piers (the cause) reach firmer ground, so the building has solid support (the effect).
td1_s1	Choose the best transition: Houston gets heavy rainstorms. ___, builders put in drains that carry rainwater away quickly.	**As a result**	Builders put in drains BECAUSE of the heavy rain. That is cause and effect, so "As a result" fits.
td2_s1	Find the mistake! Sam wrote: "Steel is strong when it is stretched. For example, the crew went home at five o'clock." Which explanation is correct?	**The second sentence is not an example of steel's strength, so "For example" does not fit, and the sentence is off-topic.**	"For example" must be followed by an example of the idea before it. When the crew went home tells nothing about steel's strength.
td1_s2	Choose the best transition: Many different workers help build an apartment building. ___, crane operators lift steel high into the air.	**For example**	Crane operators are one example of the "many different workers," so "For example" fits.
td2_s2	Find the mistake! Which pair of sentences uses a transition INCORRECTLY?	**The crane is very tall. As a result, the crew ate lunch.**	A tall crane does not cause the crew to eat lunch, so "As a result" makes no sense there. The other pairs show a real effect, a real contrast, and a real next step.

FIX THE SENTENCE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
fs1_s0	Punctuation: add the comma after the transition word. First the crew drills deep holes for the piers.	**First, the crew drills deep holes for the piers.**	When a transition like "First" starts a sentence, put a comma right after it.
fs2_s0	Capitalization: fix the three capital-letter mistakes. the crew in houston worked all through july.	**The crew in Houston worked all through July.**	Capitalize the first word of a sentence, the name of a city (Houston), and the name of a month (July).
fs3_s0	Grammar: fix the verb so it agrees with the subject. The workers pours the concrete at sunrise.	**The workers pour the concrete at sunrise.**	"Workers" is plural, so it needs the plural verb "pour," not "pours."
fs4_s0	Punctuation: fix the end mark. Why does clay soil swell when it rains.	**Why does clay soil swell when it rains?**	This sentence asks a question, so it ends with a question mark.
fs1_s1	Punctuation: add the comma after the transition word. However the storm passed quickly.	**However, the storm passed quickly.**	When "However" starts a sentence, put a comma right after it.
fs2_s1	Capitalization: fix the three capital-letter mistakes. hurricane harvey flooded houston in 2017.	**Hurricane Harvey flooded Houston in 2017.**	Capitalize the first word of the sentence, the name of a storm (Hurricane Harvey), and the name of a city (Houston).

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
fs3_s1	Grammar: fix the there / their / they're mistake. The ironworkers tied there steel bars into grids.	**The ironworkers tied their steel bars into grids.**	"Their" shows that something belongs to someone. The steel bars belong to the ironworkers, so use "their."
fs4_s1	Punctuation: add an apostrophe to show that the arm belongs to one crane. The cranes arm swung over the street.	**The crane's arm swung over the street.**	To show that something belongs to one owner, add an apostrophe and s: the crane's arm.
fs1_s2	Punctuation: add the comma after the transition. As a result the building stayed dry.	**As a result, the building stayed dry.**	When "As a result" starts a sentence, put a comma right after it.
fs2_s2	Capitalization: fix the four capital-letter mistakes. the city of houston is near the gulf of mexico.	**The city of Houston is near the Gulf of Mexico.**	Capitalize the first word of the sentence, the city name (Houston), and both important words in the name of a body of water (Gulf, Mexico).
fs3_s2	Grammar: fix the verb so it agrees with the subject. Each worker wear a hard hat.	**Each worker wears a hard hat.**	"Each worker" means one worker, so it needs the singular verb "wears."
fs4_s2	Punctuation: add the missing apostrophe in the contraction. The building isnt finished yet.	**The building isn't finished yet.**	"Isn't" is a contraction of "is not." The apostrophe takes the place of the missing letter o.

WRITER'S NOTEBOOK FOLLOW-UP (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
wf_s0	Read this paragraph. Which sentence is the best CONCLUDING sentence? / A crane operator has one of the most important jobs on a building site. First, the operator climbs a ladder to a small cab high above the ground. Next, a signal person on the ground uses hand signals and a radio to guide each lift. For example, the operator might lift a bundle of steel bars to the fifth floor. ___	**With skill and teamwork, the crane operator helps the whole building rise.**	A concluding sentence wraps up the main idea (the crane operator's important job) in a new way. The other choices add an off-topic detail, repeat a detail, or jump to a new topic.
wf_s1	Read this paragraph. Which sentence is the best TOPIC sentence? / ___ First, workers paint the walls and put in kitchen cabinets. Next, electricians install lights and outlets. Finally, a city inspector checks everything before families move in.	**Before families can move in, the inside of the building must be finished.**	Every detail is about finishing the inside of the building, so the topic sentence must state that main idea.
wf_s2	Read this paragraph. Which sentence is the best CONCLUDING sentence? / Houston summers are hard on building crews. Temperatures often climb above 90 degrees. As a result, many crews start work at sunrise. Workers also take water breaks in the shade. ___	**Planning around the heat keeps workers safe while the building rises.**	The concluding sentence should wrap up the main idea (working safely in the summer heat). The other choices go off-topic, repeat a detail word for word, or use the wrong transition.

MATCH-UP ROUND (SETS 1–3, 2 POINTS EACH)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
match1_s0	topic sentence	**tells the main idea**	First-try match earns 2 points.

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
match2_s0	supporting detail	**a fact or example that backs up the main idea**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match3_s0	transition	**connects one idea to the next**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match4_s0	concluding sentence	**wraps up the paragraph**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match5_s0	informative writing	**teaches facts about a real topic**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match1_s1	however	**shows a contrast**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match2_s1	for example	**introduces an example**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match3_s1	as a result	**shows an effect**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match4_s1	first	**shows the first step**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match5_s1	finally	**shows the last step**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match1_s2	off-topic sentence	**does not fit the main idea**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match2_s2	paragraph	**a group of sentences about one idea**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match3_s2	pier	**a deep column that holds up a building**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match4_s2	rebar	**steel bars inside concrete**	First-try match earns 2 points.
match5_s2	next	**shows the step that comes after**	First-try match earns 2 points.

SPEED TRAIL (BONUS XP ONLY, NOT SCORED)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
tt1	Which transition shows a CONTRAST?	**However**	However signals a difference between two ideas.
tt2	Where does the topic sentence usually go?	**At the beginning of the paragraph**	The topic sentence usually comes first, so the reader knows the main idea right away.
tt3	Which transition signals the LAST step?	**Finally**	Finally tells the reader this is the last step.

BOSS CHALLENGE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
b1_s0	Two-step: read the paragraph, find the off-topic sentence, then choose the best fix. / (1) Houston builders must plan for hurricanes. (2) First, engineers design roofs that hold tight in strong winds. (3) Next, builders install thick windows that resist flying objects. (4) For example, the crane operator eats lunch at noon. (5) As a result, the building can stand up to a storm.	**Sentence 4 is off-topic. Replace it with a hurricane detail, such as "Builders also raise the lowest floor to keep floodwater out."**	Every sentence should support the topic sentence about planning for hurricanes. Lunchtime has nothing to do with hurricanes, so sentence 4 must go, and a real hurricane detail makes the paragraph stronger.
b2_s0	Two-step: check the ORDER and the TRANSITIONS. Which paragraph is organized CORRECTLY?	**Cranes help build tall buildings. First, a crane lifts steel to the top floors. Next, it lowers heavy tools to the workers. Without cranes, tall buildings would take much longer to build.**	The correct paragraph has the topic sentence first, details joined by order transitions (First, Next), and a concluding sentence last. The others put the conclusion first, use "However" where there is no contrast, or include an off-topic sentence about a dog.
b1_s1	Two-step: find the topic sentence, then use the transitions to put the sentences in order. / A. Finally, workers pour concrete to fill each hole. B. Building a foundation in clay soil takes several steps. C. Next, they lower a cage of steel bars into each hole. D. First, workers drill deep holes.	**B, D, C, A**	B states the main idea, so it is the topic sentence. Then the transitions show the order: First (D), Next (C), Finally (A).
b2_s1	Mia wrote: "The crew has many different jobs. Electricians run the wires. However, plumbers connect the pipes." Which explanation is correct?	**"However" signals a contrast, but plumbers connecting pipes is just another job, not an opposite idea. A word like "Also" fits better.**	"However" is for ideas that are different or opposite. Plumbers connecting pipes simply adds another job to the list, so an adding transition such as "Also" fits.
b1_s2	Two-step: find the topic sentence, then use the transitions to put the sentences in order. / A. As a result, the building stays dry during big storms. B. Houston builders work hard to keep floodwater out. C. First, they raise the lowest floor higher off the ground. D. Next, they add drains that carry rainwater away.	**B, C, D, A**	B states the main idea, so it comes first. First (C) and Next (D) give the steps in order, and "As a result" (A) tells the effect of those steps, so it comes last.
b2_s2	Two-step: Jordan wrote first the crew pours concrete. next, it hardens. Which list names ALL of the mistakes?	**Capitalize First, add a comma after First, and capitalize Next**	Correct: First, the crew pours concrete. Next, it hardens. Each sentence starts with a capital letter, and an opening transition like "First" is followed by a comma.

Pre & Post sheet answer guide

Many items are open-ended. Grade for genuine understanding and complete sentences, not exact wording.

PRE-LESSON WARM-UP

#	Prompt	Model answer / grading note
1	Best topic sentence for a paragraph about building on clay soil	Clay soil makes building a foundation tricky. (It states the main idea; the others are off-topic.)
2	Circle the transition and name its job	“As a result” — effect (cause and effect).
3	Cross out the sentence that does not belong	“I like tacos.” It is off-topic; every other sentence is about cranes.
4	Add the missing comma	Next, the crew pours the concrete.
5	Review: which dialogue sentence is correct?	"Watch the crane," Andre said. (comma inside the closing quotation mark)

POST-LESSON CHALLENGE

#	Prompt	Model answer / grading note
1	Order the sentences	B, D, A, C (topic sentence, then First, Next, Finally).
2	Fill in the transitions	As a result, builders install thick windows. / For example, electricians run wires. / However, steel is strong when stretched.
3	Find and replace the off-topic sentence	“My uncle has a red truck.” is off-topic. Accept any replacement about what inspectors check, e.g., “They also make sure the stairs and railings are safe.”
4	Fix capitals and commas	First, the crew in Houston pours concrete. However, the rain slows them down.
5	Write an informative paragraph (5 to 6 sentences)	Grading note: a clear topic sentence first; at least three supporting details that all stay on the main idea (no off-topic sentences); at least two transitions used for the right job, each followed by a comma when it starts a sentence; a concluding sentence that restates the main idea in a new way; correct capitals and end marks. Sample: The bridge over Peace River helps our town every day. First, it lets cars and trucks cross the river quickly. Next, school buses use it to reach students on both sides. For example, my bus crosses it twice a day. As a result, people can get to work and school on time. Our bridge keeps the whole town connected.

★ CHALLENGE

#	Prompt	Model answer / grading note
1	Two-paragraph informative piece	Grading note: each paragraph has its own topic sentence and one main idea; supporting details stay on topic; at least four different transitions used correctly; a concluding sentence wraps up both paragraphs. Praise details that come from real observation of the student’s community.